renowned as ‘a good singer and actor’ who took part in college plays, nonetheless also, ‘he was a voracious reader – as the Jail Notebook testifies, and had a fine understanding of literature’.[15]

One reason for this reckoning is, as Chris Moffat has argued, that ‘Bhagat Singh is often left to speak for himself in histories written’.[16] This is because most books written on him have relied heavily on the citation of large tracts from his writings and speeches, leaving it to the reader to gauge the depth and nuance of the stance that he took during his short life. The result is that, invariably, ‘over one-third’ of a book may consist of ‘appended documents’[17] and in other cases ‘the author may reproduce documents in their entirety allowing the protagonist to interject at critical moments’,[18] not to mention those books where ‘scanned version of newspaper articles and written notes are provided . . .’.[19] They are intended to be, according to Moffat, ‘more than simple riches’ because ‘these writings are wielded as though they will – through the very power of their contents – *change* or *incite* the reader’.[20] In this way, there is developed a relationship between the writer and the now-gone Bhagat Singh of ‘perfect necromancy’ that is ultimately ‘a more genuine communication with the dead’ that is ‘for the sake of the present and the future’.[21]

For his part, Moffat sets out on a different course as he searches for a ‘corrective’ which is ‘not a routine matter of historical excavation but an interventionist act of historical emendation’. The task at hand, he argues, must be ‘to challenge certainties’ and to ‘transform expectations’. This being so, the ‘impulse’ must be ‘to question the form that this pantheon has taken’. The questions to grapple with are, ‘How can a figure as impressive as Bhagat Singh be relegated to the periphery? What has been lost in these years of distortion and simplification? And what can be gained by finally “knowing”, by arriving at his “true” form at long last?’[22] This indeed is the question for us today. There is no claim here to finding a definitive answer. Rather, the claim is to a continuing endeavour or, as Moffat proclaims, ‘to identify obscured alternatives’.[23] If we could identify some key statements and writings of Bhagat Singh and his accomplices, can we truly acquire an